Kelsey Community School
Book Challenge Outreach and Communication Plan

Challenge 08

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Summary of Event

A school parent and Opaskwayak Council member has raised concerns about Indigenous representation in four books at Kelsey Community School Library: *Little House on the Prairie* (Laura Ingalls Wilder), *The Education of Little Tree* (Forrest Carter), *The Indian in the Cupboard* (Lynne Reid Banks), and *The Sign of the Beaver* (Elizabeth George Speare). They have urged the school division to adopt a policy against purchasing materials with racist stereotypes and seek direct input from the librarian on future selections and support for diversity-focused community groups.

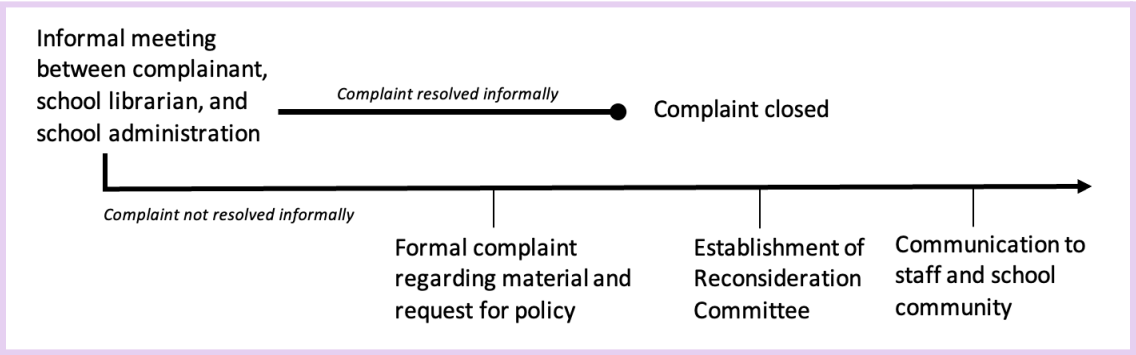
Rationale

This document outlines the coordinated material and policy reconsideration process within the framework of district and provincial policies, such as Manitoba's Indigenous Education Policy Framework, and recommendations from the Manitoba School Library Association. Preparedness, transparency, and communication are essential to minimizing the impact of material challenges. This outreach and communication plan aims to maintain trust between the community and the school while sustaining collaborative educational spaces, in adherence with Manitoba's Community Schools Program. This document is meant as a guide, to be shared openly, to establish clear roles and responsibilities and allow for a collaborative process. This document will:

- Outline the material reconsideration process;
- Outline roles and responsibilities of key parties;
- Develop communication plans for the complainant, staff, the school community, and possible media releases;
- Detail a hypothetical SWOT analysis; and
- Include references to relevant policies and information resources.

Reconsideration Process

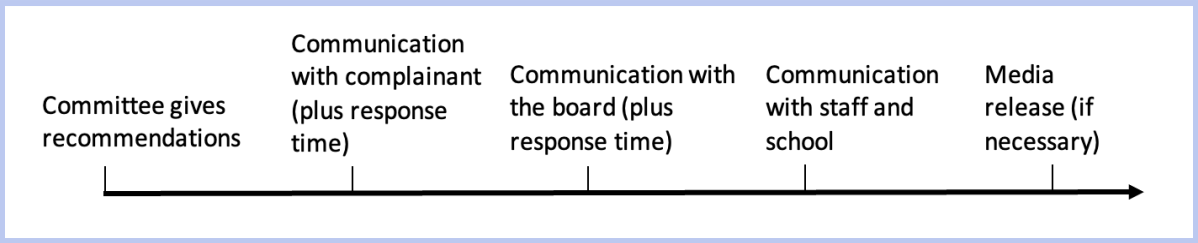
Phase One: Informal complaint to formal complaint



Roles and Responsibilities
School Librarian and School Administration: • Arrange a meeting with the complainant (See Communication Plan for more detail) • School Librarian to research and prepare information and resources relating to challenges to the listed material.

- School Administration to develop understanding of similar material challenges/intellectual freedom
- If a formal challenge is submitted to:
  - Develop a Reconsideration Committee that reflects the community and includes administration, school librarian, teachers, and parents/community members.
  - Develop communications for staff and the school community.
  - Share resources with involved parties on intellectual freedom and material challenges.

Phase Two: Committee recommendations and communications



Roles and Responsibilities

School Librarian/School Administration (in collaboration):

- Establish a processes timeline with the complainant
- Communicate any relevant updates/decisions with involved parties.
- Respond to questions and concerns from the school community (in accordance with the communication plan).
- Communicate any concerns to the Kelsey School Division Board of Trustees.
- Review collections development policy.
- Report complaint to CFLA database.

Reconsideration Committee:

- Consult reviews, professional recommendations, and educational standards to inform the decision-making process.
- Be knowledgeable about the resource being challenged and have read the entire work.
- Conduct review in a timely manner, following the timeline provided by school administration.
- Document decision making process and provide meeting minutes.
- Write a formal response to be distributed by school administration.
- If required, write suggested amendments to the collections development policy.

School Staff:

- Respond to simple questions or concerns from parents and students
- Refer complex questions/concerns to school administration

Board of Trustees (Community Liaison Committee, Education Liaison Committee, Policy Committee):

- Review background literature and formal responses from the Reconsideration Committee.
- If required, vote on policy suggestions.
- Prepare possible media responses.

Communication Plan

Effective communication with all stakeholders is essential to maintaining transparency and trust between the school and the community. Raising awareness about the processes and potential impacts of material challenges enables informed decision-making that upholds diverse perspectives, experiences, abilities, and identities in the school's library collection. All stakeholders will have access (both online and in print) to the following resources:

- The Manitoba School Library Association's Toolkit for Diverse Collection Development and Intellectual Freedom in Manitoba Schools
- The Kelsey School Division Policy Manual
- Mamàhtawisiwin: The Wonder We Are Born With—An Indigenous Education Policy Framework
- Various supporting case studies and resources (see additional resources)

Messaging to the Complainant

The librarian and the school administration will suggest a meeting with the complainant. The complainant may choose the meeting format (in-person, Zoom, etc.), location, and additional attendees, such as community Elders. Building a relationship with the parent is crucial, as highlighted in Manitoba's Community Schools Act 3(c), which states that "parents are partners in their children's education and are encouraged and offered opportunities to have meaningful involvement in their children's education and the planning process for the school." (Bill 12) The complainant's role in initiating the review process and establishing a timeline ensures that community relations remain a priority. While the meeting will be informal and relationship-focused, minutes will be recorded for accountability.

Key components of shared information:

- The librarian's role in the broader contexts of intellectual freedom and a child's right to read.
- Tools available for addressing concerns, including formal materials challenges and policy change requests.
- Explanation of the formal process, emphasizing transparency, accountability, and community participation to ensure thoughtful reconsideration and alignment with Kelsey School Division strategic initiatives.

If a formal complaint is filed, communication will continue through the complainant's preferred method (email, phone, or in person). Updates on committee formation, decisions, and relevant information will be shared throughout the process.

Messaging for Staff

Staff must remain informed about the situation, process, and policies to maintain a cohesive school community. Awareness ensures effective communication with parents and students. Updates will be provided via email and staff meetings.

Key messaging points for staff:

- Community concerns about library materials are taken seriously.
- The school is following a recommended reconsideration process developed by the Manitoba School Library Association.
- The process is guided by ethical principles, including intellectual freedom and diversity and inclusion.
- Serious concerns or questions should be directed to school administration.

Messaging for Parents/Parents Advisory Committee (PAC)

Parents will receive information through the school listserv and PAC meetings. The first communication will be sent after a formal complaint is submitted. The Reconsideration Committee will include parent representatives, and the initial communication will include a call for submissions outlining the role's expectations.

Key messaging points for parents:

- Material challenges from parents and community members are taken seriously.
- The school library collection aligns with the collections development policy.
- A Reconsideration Committee is being formed, and parent representatives are needed:
    - Representatives must read the works in full.
    - Representatives must review supporting documents on collections development, school policies, and intellectual freedom.
    - Representatives must attend committee meetings.
- Questions or concerns can be directed to school administration.

Media Release:

All media releases are developed and disseminated by the Board of Trustees, with the Chair of the Board functioning as representative (Kelsey School Division, 2024, p.20) Recommendations for messaging by the Reconsideration Committee and the school will be included in the formal letter submitted to the Board after the reconsideration process.

Preliminary SWOT Analysis

- *Strengths:* The strong internal policy, based on provincial and school district guidelines, emphasizes direct communication and transparency and is used to base decision-making as the situation develops.
- *Weaknesses*: Potential weaknesses of the outreach plan include miscommunication within the chain of command. For example, there is no particular stance on privacy—are complaints and/or complainant identity made public? Consider as well that stakeholders may feel like concerns are superficially met with "platitudes and political non-answers"(Lederman, 2022).
- *Opportunities*: Offer formal training and role-playing of hypothetical scenarios for staff. Provide training for teachers on facilitating classroom discussions on critical literacy (weeded books can become part of such a toolkit) including opportunities for students to share their unique experiences among peers with a diversity of perspectives. Consider involving Opaskwayak knowledge keepers in future acquisition policy development.
- *Threats:* Depending on committee recommendations, community members may ask whether Indigenous complaints are given special priority consideration and whether Opaskwayak Council complaints are given more weight than those of individual community members. In addition, any action taken in response to this challenge risks setting a precedent that could present future problems for the Kelsey Community School library, and damage trust between Kelsey Community School and the local community. See, for example, Peel School Board's decision to remove all materials published before 2008 (Alphonso, 2023) or a Houston school district which has faced a challenge about books with 'lived-experience' perspectives (Goodman, 2024). Is precedent being set for unwanted books to be vandalised so as to prematurely weed them?

References

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Kelsey School Division. (2024, October 23). *Kelsey School Division Policy Manual*.

Manitoba Education and Early Childhood Learning. (2022). *Mamàhtawisiwin: The Wonder We Are Born With—An Indigenous Education Policy Framework*.

Manitoba School Library Association. (2023, July 11). *Toolkit for Diverse Collection Development and Intellectual Freedom in Manitoba Schools*.

Additional Resources

Alphonso, C. (2023). Peel school board faces backlash for removing books published before 2008 from its libraries: Parents, teachers and school staff raise concerns after school libraries remove books on Canadian history, literary classics and antisemitism, including The Diary of a Young Girl by Anne Frank. *The Globe and Mail*. Retrieved from https://www.proquest.com/blogs-podcasts-websites/peel-school-board-faces-backlash-removing-books/docview/2864336588/se-2

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Goodman, C. (2024, November 11). 'This is not a history class': Inside a Katy ISD debate over a Native American novel. Houston Chronicle. https://www.houstonchronicle.com/neighborhood/katy/article/katy-isd-board-ban-book-19885981.php

Guelph Public Libraries. (n.d.). *Summary of Complaint - The Education of Little Tree.*

Lederman, M. (2022). Durham school board creates controversy after children's book pulled from shelves: Indigenous author David A. Robertson's book The Great Bear was pulled from library shelves following information that the book contained content 'that could be harmful to Indigenous students and families'. Toronto: The Globe and Mail. Retrieved from https://www.proquest.com/blogs-podcasts-websites/durham-school-board-creates-controversy-after/docview/2652695652/se-2

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Rose, C., and Eshkibok, M. (2007, April 11). More on Elizabeth George Speare's The Sign of The Beaver. *American Indians in Children's Literature.* https://americanindiansinchildrensliterature.blogspot.com/2007/04/more-on-sign-of-beaver-below-is-essay.html

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